Describing landmarks: adjectives and adjective order

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to describe a landmark with several adjectives placed in the correct order, as in "a magnificent old Roman stone theatre".

The idea in two lines: Adjectives describe nouns and never change their form in English (one old tower, two old towers). When we use more than one adjective, they follow a fixed order: opinion first, then size, age, shape, colour, origin, material and purpose.

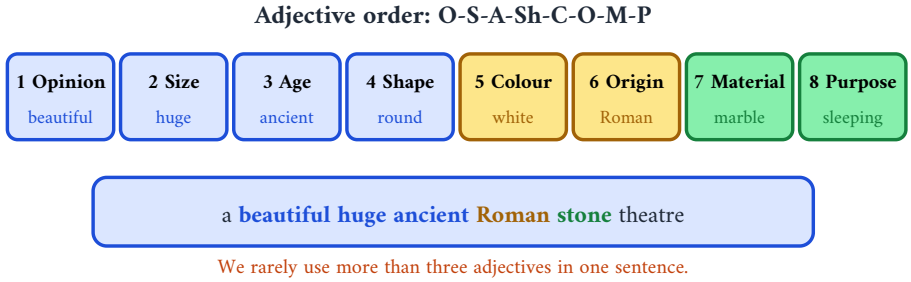


Figure 1: The usual order of adjectives before a noun, with an example describing a landmark.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. An **adjective** gives information about a noun: *tall, old, famous, stone*. It has no plural form and no gender: *two tall minarets*, not "talls".
2. Adjectives come **before the noun** (*a famous mosque*) or **after the verb be** and verbs like *look, seem* (*The mosque is famous*).
3. The **order of adjectives** is: opinion, size, age, shape, colour, origin, material, purpose, then the noun. Remember the phrase "OSAShCOMP".
4. **Opinion adjectives** (*wonderful, impressive, boring*) always come first because they express what we think, not a fact.
5. Adjectives of **origin** (nationality) take a capital letter: *Algerian, Egyptian, Chinese*.
6. Between two adjectives of the **same type** we use *and*: *a red and white flag*. Between different types, no comma: *a tall old tower*.

7. Useful landmark adjectives: **ancient, historic, impressive, enormous, sacred, well-preserved**.

🟢 Examples

1. Put in order: *mosque / white / impressive / Ottoman*. **Answer:** an impressive white Ottoman mosque. **Explanation:** opinion (impressive) → colour (white) → origin (Ottoman) → noun.
2. Put in order: *walls / stone / huge / old*. **Answer:** huge old stone walls. **Explanation:** size (huge) → age (old) → material (stone). The adjectives stay singular even though "walls" is plural.
3. Describe the Casbah of Algiers in one sentence. **Answer:** The Casbah is a fascinating old Algerian quarter with narrow winding streets. **Explanation:** opinion → age → origin; then size (narrow) before shape (winding).

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Adding -s to adjectives: "two *bigs* towers". Adjectives never take a plural ending.
- Putting the adjective after the noun as in French or Arabic: "a tower *tall*". In English the adjective comes before the noun.
- Placing origin or material before opinion: "a stone beautiful bridge" instead of *a beautiful stone bridge*.
- Forgetting the capital letter on nationality adjectives: "roman ruins" instead of *Roman ruins*.

🟡 Quick review

- Adjective + noun; the adjective never changes its form.
- Order: Opinion, Size, Age, Shape, Colour, Origin, Material, Purpose.
- Opinion always first; material comes just before purpose (or before the noun if there is no purpose adjective).
- Nationality adjectives take a capital letter.
- In your BEM paragraph, two or three well-ordered adjectives are enough.